Culture

En analys från Swedish Subsidiarity

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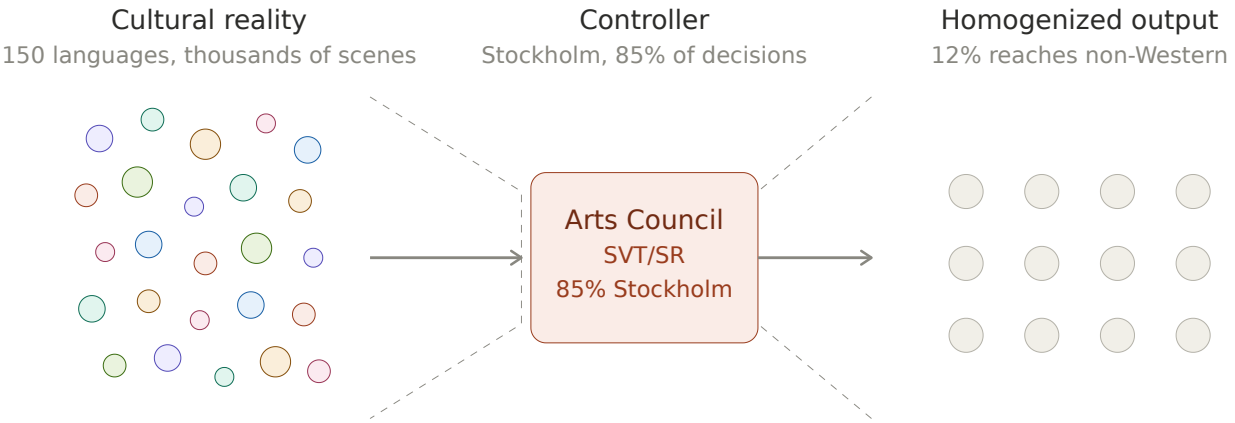
Culture and media: the storytelling monopoly

The homogenization paradox

Sweden celebrates diversity—20% foreign-born, 150 languages, pride in immigrants' contributions. Yet only 12% of cultural support reaches non-Western expressions. SVT/SR's programming reflects Stockholm's perspective to 70%. 85% of cultural policy decision-making is concentrated in the capital.

The paradox: A nation that claims to value creativity and diversity has built a media and cultural system that standardizes, homogenizes, and in practice depletes the very variation it celebrates.

The cybernetic error: Culture is a phenomenon with *high variance*—it arises in thousands of local communities, immigrant groups, subcultures, and language communities. Cultural institutions (the Swedish Arts Council, SVT/SR, museums, libraries) are control units with *low variance*—they apply standardized quality measures, centralized selection decisions, and Stockholm's aesthetic preferences. Attempting to control cultural diversity through centralized institutions violates Ashby's law. The result: cultural poverty disguised as excellence.



Ashby’s law: low variety in the controller cannot absorb high variety in the environment Result: cultural poverty disguised as excellence

Active system failures (in brief)

- **The public service monopoly**: SEK 9 billion/year to SVT/SR, but programming decisions are made in Stockholm. Melodifestivalen eats up a large part of the entertainment budget while local scenes starve.
- **The Arts Council's Stockholm filter**: Board members and assessors live in or near the capital. Their taste becomes national policy—the immigrant music scene in Gothenburg receives a fraction of the funding per capita compared to established Stockholm institutions.
- **The burden of the Swedish canon**: The curriculum's "Swedish cultural heritage" (Vikings, the Middle Ages, 19th-century literature) marginalizes the 20% of students from different backgrounds. Somali children learn about Vikings but nothing about their parents' poetry.
- **The universalism of libraries**: The demand for "something for everyone" results in superficial collections that do not adequately serve any group. Arabic-speaking areas receive as many Swedish classics as Arabic literature.
- **The historical monopoly of museums**: Official history freezes 19th-century folk traditions while contemporary immigrant culture is ignored.
- **Language policy assimilation**: Cultural support is only given to expressions in Swedish—a Kurdish poet in Botkyrka cannot receive funding to write in Kurdish.

Subsidiarity-based measures

Below are five action areas. Each area has its own page with concrete pilots, budgets, rule changes, and analysis of resistance.

→ Grants for everyday culture

SEK 5,000 to non-professional cultural creators—Somali grandmothers recording cooking songs, teenagers documenting skateboard culture. Simple video application, no qualifications required. 10,000 grants/year = SEK 50 million.

→ Hyperlocal public service

Break SVT/SR's broadcasting monopoly. Three regions get their own channels with local boards and guaranteed funding per capita. Which section of the Radio and Television Act needs to be amended? How much does a local channel in Kiruna cost?

→ Language community councils

Reserve 1% of the cultural budget for production in languages other than Swedish. Councils for Arabic, Kurdish, Somali, etc., distribute funds based on the number of speakers in each municipality. A Kurdish poet

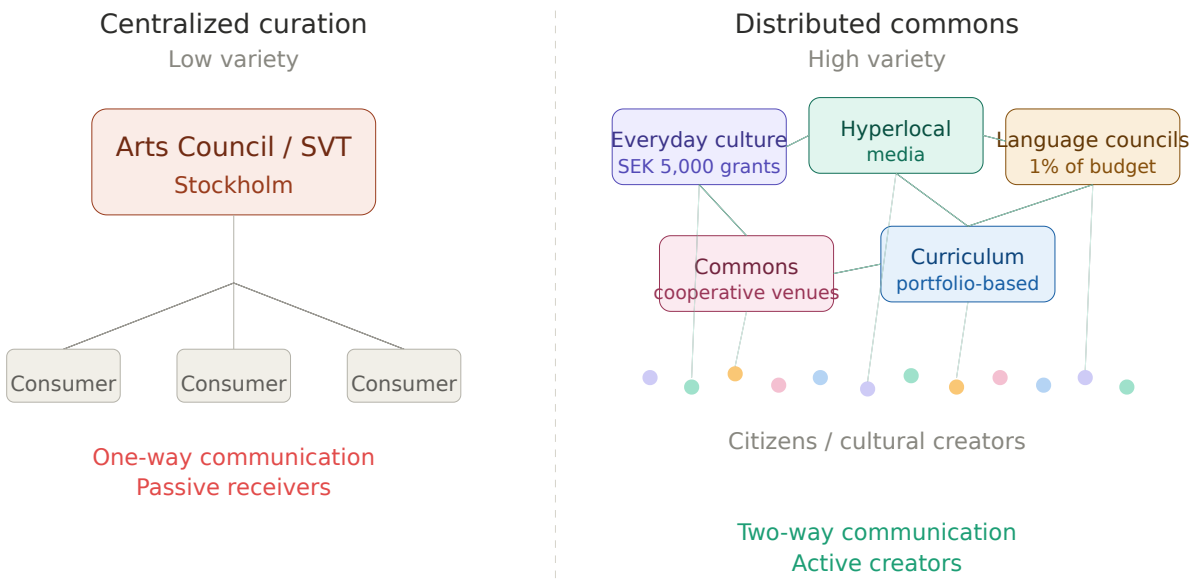
in Botkyrka would then apply to the Kurdish council—not to the Arts Council in Stockholm.

→ Cultural commons

Transform municipal cultural centers into community-controlled cooperatives (one member, one vote). 70% of the program is determined by local groups, 30% is professionally curated. How do you change the Local Government Act to enable this?

→ A multicultural curriculum

Replace the narrow canon with portfolio-based cultural heritage education. Students in Tensta document their families' oral traditions *at the same time* as they learn about the Viking Age. Pilot in five schools with measurable effects on engagement and identity.



Implementation: from theory to practice

Phase 1 (1–3 years): Month for everyday culture—a national campaign where all Swedes share their cultural practices on `MinKultur.se`. Ten municipalities test participatory budgeting for cultural decisions. Establish 100 language stages at libraries.

Phase 2 (3–7 years): Transform 100 cultural centers in suburbs into cultural commons. Three regions launch hyperlocal public service channels. The language community councils receive their first budget.

Phase 3 (7–15 years): Culture banks—resource hubs with equipment, archives, and knowledge sharing in every municipality. The profession of "culture guide" (one per 5,000 inhabitants) maps local assets and

connects creators.

The Swedish advantage

Sweden has a design culture, digital competence, progressive rhetoric, relative wealth, and a small population—all factors that make system change possible. The only thing missing is the decision to begin.

Expected resistance (in brief)

Concern	Response
"Quality will drop if we fund amateurs"	The current system defines quality narrowly around professional production standards. Different communities have different quality measures—democratization is not a lowering of standards.
"Swedish culture will be eroded"	Swedish culture has always changed through incorporation. Immigrant traditions *become* Swedish through living practice.
"SVT/SR will fight back"	Demand that public service match its funding with local co-production. Hyperlocal pilots will demonstrate the alternative.
"Co-optation—the establishment will start its own 'local' labels"	Cooperative ownership model and federated architecture (no one can shut down the network). Statutory definition of "local" in public procurement.

Conclusion: choose between apparent diversity and real variation

Today's cultural policy is not progressive—it is **centralized homogenization disguised as diversity rhetoric**. A system where 85% of decisions are made in Stockholm cannot serve a nation with 150 languages and thousands of local performing artists.

The choice is simple: continue to fund Melodifestivalen and the Royal Swedish Opera while suburban cultural creators starve—or begin the transition with grants for everyday culture, hyperlocal public service, and language community councils.

Three things you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Allocate SEK 500,000 for a pilot project with grants for non-professional cultural creators. Use the municipality's autonomy—you do not need to ask the government.

If you are a librarian or cultural worker: Start a language stage in your library—once a month, entirely in Arabic, Kurdish, or Somali. Invite local poets and musicians.

If you are a citizen: Attend a cultural evening in an area you have never visited. Ask your municipality what they are doing to support culture that does *not* come from established institutions.

This analysis applies cybernetic principles (Ashby's law of requisite variety) to Swedish cultural policy. For deeper measures, click on the links above.

Grants for everyday culture

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Summary: SEK 5,000 to non-professional cultural creators—Somali grandmothers recording cooking songs, teenagers documenting skateboard culture, pensioners writing local history in their own language. Simple video application, no qualifications required. 10,000 grants per year = SEK 50 million, less than 0.5% of the Arts Council's budget. The purpose: to recognize that most cultural creation takes place outside institutions.

The mechanism

Today, almost all cultural support goes to professional actors with a documented track record, education, and often membership in industry organizations. This excludes the vast majority of actual cultural creators—those who create at home, in associations, online, in the neighborhood.

The measure: A new grant of SEK 5,000 per project, with no requirements for:

- Previous exhibitions or publications
- Artistic education
- Membership in any organization
- Translation into Swedish

What the grant can be used for:

- Recording equipment (microphone, camera)
- Materials (fabric, paint, clay)
- Renting a venue for an evening
- Printing a small edition of books or fanzines
- Time to complete the work

What the grant may not be used for:

- Ongoing operating costs
- Investments in a professional studio that is then rented out
- Travel outside Sweden

The application process – designed for simplicity

Step 1: Record a short video (max 3 minutes) where you show or talk about what you want to create. State what you need the money for. The video is uploaded to a simple platform (MinKultur.se).

Step 2: No form with a personal identity number, certificates, or references. Just a button: "Submit". The system generates a digital receipt.

Step 3: Assessment is done by **previous recipients**—not by professional cultural bureaucrats. Every person who received a grant one year can participate in assessing other people's applications the next year (voluntarily, for a small fee). This creates a self-reinforcing loop of review and learning.

Step 4: Notification within 30 days. The money is paid directly to a Swish account linked to the personal identity number (to reduce the risk of fraud).

Pilot design – ten municipalities first

Pilot phase 1 (year 1): Ten municipalities with different profiles (large city, rural area, high proportion of foreign-born) receive SEK 1 million each—a total of SEK 10 million. Each municipality distributes 200 grants of SEK 5,000.

Selection criteria for pilot municipalities:

- Malmö (high proportion of foreign-born, strong association culture)
- Kiruna (sparsely populated area, Sami and newly arrived culture)
- Botkyrka (great diversity, existing cultural life outside the establishment)
- Umeå (student city, youth subcultures)
- Gothenburg (immigrant music scene)
- Östersund (local heritage culture, small-scale authorship)
- Norrköping (industrial heritage, working-class culture)
- Järfälla (suburb of Stockholm, low degree of professional cultural life)
- Hässleholm (rural municipality with smallholder tradition)
- Stockholm (to test whether even central Stockholm has invisible everyday culture)

Evaluation: After one year, the following are measured:

- Number of submitted applications (target: at least 500 per municipality)
- Proportion who have never previously received cultural support (target: >80%)
- Proportion with a foreign background or mother tongue other than Swedish (target: proportional to the municipality's population)
- Perceived effect – survey to recipients ("Did you feel seen as a cultural creator?")

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost
10,000 grants of SEK 5,000	SEK 50 million
Platform (MinKultur.se) operation and development	SEK 2 million
Assessor fees (1000 people at SEK 2000)	SEK 2 million
Municipal administration (0.5 full-time per pilot municipality)	SEK 3 million
Evaluation and dissemination	SEK 1 million
Total	**SEK 58 million**

Financing: Reallocation within the Arts Council's budget (total approx. SEK 12 billion annually). SEK 58 million is **0.48%**—a minor reprioritization from large institutions to everyday culture.

Regulatory changes required

1. **New regulation at the Arts Council** – "Grants for non-professional cultural creation". Proposed text: *"Support may be provided to natural persons to carry out cultural expressions in the form of, for example, music, storytelling, crafts, film, poetry, dance, or other artistic design. The applicant does not need to be a professional or have previous qualifications."*
2. **Change in the Freedom of the Press Act** (regarding grants for printed matter)? No, not necessary—the grant is general, not linked to a publishing permit.
3. **General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR)** – The platform must handle personal data (videos, Swish linked to personal identity numbers). But since it is public administration, this can be solved with standard solutions.

Expected resistance and answers

"This will be a wild explosion of low-quality junk."

Answer: Quality is not a universal characteristic. What one immigrant group experiences as beautiful and meaningful may not fit into the aesthetics of a Stockholm curator. The purpose is not to produce "good" culture according to professional standards—but to recognize that culture is what people do. Let 10,000 flowers bloom. Some will be ugly flowers in the eyes of others. That is the price of democracy.

"Professional cultural creators will be disadvantaged."

Answer: Professionals already have hundreds of forms of support: working grants, project grants, exhibition compensation, purchases for museums, tour support, etchttps://www.google.com/search?q=.. The everyday culture grant is a small pot (0.5% of the Arts Council's budget) that does not compete with professional funding. It is an addition, not a reallocation from professionals.

"Who protects against fraud and duplicate applications?"

Answer: The platform links applications to personal identity numbers. A person can receive a maximum of one grant per year. Swish payout to a verified account. Spot checks (5% of grants) where the recipient must show a receipt for what the money was used for. If someone cheats (e.g., buys a video game instead of recording equipment)—repayment demand and suspension for two years.

"Assessment by previous recipients – they have no competence."

Answer: What competence is required to determine whether a video of a Somali grandmother singing a cooking song is "worth" SEK 5,000? The point is that there is no objective quality assessment—just a check that the application is genuine and feasible. Previous recipients can easily see if an application is frivolous or fabricated. That is enough.

"The municipalities will shut it down – no energy."

Answer: That is why the pilot is first with ten municipalities that *want* to test it. After a successful pilot, a standardized model is created that other municipalities can copy with minimal administration. The platform handles the heavy lifting—the municipality only needs to appoint a contact person for information and simple handling of appeals.

Swedish examples to build on

- **Kulturbryggan** (The Swedish Arts Council) – already testing grassroots financing, but retaining requirements for professional anchoring. The everyday culture grant goes further.
- **The Swedish Inheritance Fund (Allmänna arvsfonden)** – has "small change" for children's and young people's ideas, but is not open to adults.
- **Braille for the visually impaired** – a model for how grants can be simple and uncomplicated.
- **Village association grants (Byalagsbidrag)** (The Swedish Board of Agriculture) – available for rural development, but requires an association. The everyday culture grant goes to individuals.

No Swedish model does exactly this today—so we are creating a new one.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Submit a budget request of SEK 1 million for "grants for non-professional cultural creation" in your municipality. Use the text above as a basis.

If you are a culture secretary: Start a simple test version with post-it notes and a petty cash box—let 10 people in your area apply for SEK 5,000 each. Learn from the process.

If you are a cultural creator (professional or not): Spread the idea to your networks. The more people who demand that "everyday culture counts," the faster the change will happen.

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Hyperlocal public service

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Summary: Break SVT/SR's broadcasting monopoly. Three regions receive their own public service channels with local boards and guaranteed funding per capita (equivalent to 5% of current license funds). The goal: let Kiruna reflect Kiruna, not Stockholm. Today, SEK 9 billion/year goes to public service—of which SEK 0 is guaranteed for local programming autonomy.

The mechanism

Today, SVT and SR have a statutory mandate to reflect the entire country, but decisions on budget, program purchases, greenlighting, and broadcast times are made in Stockholm. Local editorial offices exist—but they report to Stockholm and have no independent budget or broadcasting rights.

The measure: Create a new category of public service actors: **hyperlocal media cooperatives**. They receive:

- A guaranteed share of the public service fee (5% of the total, i.e., approx. SEK 450 million/year).
- The right to broadcast digitally (web, apps, DAB+) within a defined region.
- A local board elected by the members (one member, one vote—no political control).
- A requirement that at least 70% of the content is produced within the region.

What they are allowed to do (which SVT/SR does not permit today):

- Bring in local advertisers (an exception to the public service ban).
- Broadcast in languages other than Swedish without translation requirements.
- Spend the entire budget on self-produced content—no compulsion to buy from Stockholm.

Pilot design – three regions first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): Three regions with different conditions are granted status as hyperlocal public service channels and guaranteed funding per capita.

Pilot 1: Kiruna (sparsely populated area, Sami population, border region)

- Population: 23,000.
- Annual guarantee: 23,000 × SEK 450 = SEK 10.4 million (based on the current public service cost per capita of approx. SEK 900—the pilot receives half).
- Mission: Sami language broadcasting, mining-related news, weather, and mountain information.
- Organizational form: Economic association with members living in the municipality.

Pilot 2: Botkyrka (suburb with high diversity)

- Population: 95,000.
- Annual guarantee: SEK 42.8 million.
- Mission: Broadcasts in Arabic, Somali, Turkish, and Spanish. Integration, local sports clubs, youth culture.
- Organizational form: Foundation with a member council (to avoid political co-optation).

Pilot 3: Västra Götaland (large region, but with weak local media)

- Population: 1.7 million.
- Annual guarantee: SEK 765 million—a significant sum, but small compared to SVT's total budget of SEK 9 billion.
- Mission: Divide into 6 local nodes (Gothenburg, Skaraborg, Sjuhärad, Fyrbodal, Norra Älvsborg, Göta älv). Each node has its own budget and board.
- Organizational form: Cooperative federation—local nodes collaborate via a shared platform but govern themselves.

Evaluation criteria after 3 years:

- Proportion of the population that consumes hyperlocal media at least once a week (target: >40%).
- Proportion of content that is not translated from national media (target: >70%).
- Linguistic diversity—number of broadcast hours per week in languages other than Swedish.
- Trust—measured with the same questions as the trust barometer for SVT.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Radio and Television Act (2010:1042)**—add a new section: *"Hyperlocal public service operations may be conducted by a cooperative or foundation that operates exclusively within a municipality or region. Such operations are exempt from the requirement to be ad-free in accordance with Chapter 7, Section 4, but only for local advertising directed at the area."*

2. **Ordinance on public service financing**—reserve 5% of the public service fee for hyperlocal actors. Distribution per capita based on population (adjusted for sparsely populated areas—Kiruna receives a higher per capita rate).
3. **Change in the broadcasting license for SVT/SR**—introduce the requirement that SVT/SR must co-produce with hyperlocal channels to be allowed to broadcast local programs in the region themselves (to avoid competition through outbidding).

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost
5% of the public service fee (SEK 9.0 billion × 0.05)	SEK 450 million
Pilot 1 (Kiruna)	SEK 10 million
Pilot 2 (Botkyrka)	SEK 43 million
Pilot 3 (Västra Götaland)	SEK 765 million (of which SEK 450 million is already allocated—the rest from the region?)

Financing: The public service fee is already decided. Reallocation within the system—no new taxes. For pilot 3, an extra regional surcharge or a lower guarantee level (e.g., SEK 250 per capita) may be required.

Alternatively: **Earmark 0.5% of SVT/SR's current budget** (SEK 45 million) for three pilots—enough to test the model. Scale up only after evaluation.

Expected resistance and answers

"Hyperlocal channels will become pure background noise—no quality."

Answer: Today, SVT has a monopoly on the definition of quality. A neighborhood watch program in Kiruna reporting on reindeer sorting and mining accidents may have higher relevance for the viewer than a documentary on Stockholm fashion. Quality measured as *usefulness for the target group*—not as production value.

"Advertising in public service destroys trust."

Answer: Hyperlocal channels may only sell advertising space to local businesses (the pizzeria, the car dealer, the construction company). That is a different matter from national advertising channels. And it is optional—

the channel can choose to forgo advertising if it wants. The point is to provide an extra source of income that does not exist in today's system.

"SVT/SR will appeal and lobby against it."

Answer: Yes, likely. But their mission is to serve the whole country. If they refuse to share the funding, politicians can make demands: "Either you start broadcasting at least 30% local content per region—or we open up for hyperlocal alternatives." SVT has had 50 years to solve local broadcasting. It has not worked. Time for new solutions.

"But who will review that they don't become political megaphones?"

Answer: The same regulations as for SVT apply—broadcasting licenses with requirements for impartiality, corrections, and a responsible publisher. The difference: instead of a politically appointed board (as today), hyperlocal channels have member-governed boards. Democratic, not party political.

"No one will have the energy to start a channel—too complicated."

Answer: That is why there are pilots—we finance the start-up costs. The model is deliberately simple: an association of 10 people can apply for status. The platform technology (streaming, web, apps) is already available as open-source code from, for example, Owncast or PeerTube. The municipality can provide technical support.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Community radio (Närradion)**—has existed since 1979, but with extremely limited resources (many broadcast voluntarily with poor reach). Our proposal provides guaranteed funding.
- **UR Sami**—part of the public service, but governed from Stockholm. The example shows that it is possible to broadcast in minority languages—but it is not scaled up.
- **The Open Channel (Öppna Kanalen)** (in Malmö, Gothenburg, Stockholm)—citizen TV that broadcasts all sorts of things, but without guaranteed funding and with an unclear mission. Our proposal provides clarity and money.
- **Danmarks Radio** has the "Local Radio and TV Committee" (Lokalradio- og tv-udvalget) which distributes license funds to local stations. Sweden has no equivalent. Copy the Danish model.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a Member of Parliament: Submit a motion to amend the Radio and Television Act to enable hyperlocal public service channels. Use the text above as a basis.

If you are a journalist or media producer: Start a non-profit association in your municipality. Gather 10 people. Send a letter to the Committee on Cultural Affairs demanding pilot funds.

If you are a municipal politician: Allocate SEK 100,000 for a feasibility study on what a hyperlocal channel could look like in your specific municipality. Connect it to universities, libraries, and associations.

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Language community councils

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Summary: 1% of the national cultural budget (approx. SEK 120 million) is reserved for cultural production in languages other than Swedish. The funds are distributed by language community councils—one for Arabic, one for Kurdish, one for Somali, one for Finnish, etc.—based on the number of speakers in each municipality. A Kurdish poet in Botkyrka can finally receive funding to write in Kurdish, without the requirement of a Swedish translation. The goal: to stop economically forced language death.

The mechanism

Today, almost all cultural support (the Swedish Arts Council, municipalities, regions) requires that the application and the finished production are in Swedish—or at least translated into Swedish. This forces cultural creators with a different mother tongue to either:

- Translate their work (expensive, time-consuming, and much is lost in translation)
- Forgo support and produce anyway (made invisible)
- Abandon their language entirely and write/sing in Swedish (assimilation)

The measure: Create **language community councils**—self-governing bodies for every major language group (defined as at least 5,000 speakers in Sweden). The councils receive:

- An annual pot based on the number of speakers in Sweden (adjusted for municipal distribution)
- Full decision-making authority over how the money is used (grants for poets, musicians, theaters, magazines, podcasters)
- The right to assess applications in their own language, without the requirement for Swedish translation
- Simple administration via a digital platform

What the money can be used for:

- Production of literature, music, performing arts, film, podcasts in the language
- Language preservation projects (documentation of dialects, oral traditions)
- Translation *from* Swedish into the language (the reverse of today)
- Guest performances and tours within the language community (e.g., an Assyrian singer from Södertälje visiting Norrköping)

Which languages get councils?

Criterion: At least 5,000 speakers in Sweden (according to Statistics Sweden's language statistics, or self-reporting). This results in councils for:

Language	Estimated number of speakers	Annual pot (1% of cultural budget per capita)
Arabic	400,000	SEK 48 million
Kurdish (Sorani/Kurmanji)	100,000	SEK 12 million
Somali	70,000	SEK 8.4 million
Finnish (incl. Meänkieli)	200,000	SEK 24 million
Bosnian/Croatian/Serbian	80,000	SEK 9.6 million
Persian (Dari/Farsi)	50,000	SEK 6 million
Tigrinya	25,000	SEK 3 million
Greek	15,000	SEK 1.8 million
Turkish	10,000	SEK 1.2 million
Total	**approx. 950,000**	**SEK 114 million**

(The remaining approx. SEK 6 million of the 1% pot goes to administration and smaller language groups under 5,000, who share a common pot.)

Pilot design – four languages first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): Start councils for the four largest language groups: Arabic, Kurdish, Somali, Finnish/Meänkieli. Each council receives a smaller pot the first year (20% of the full level) to build the organization.

The Arabic council (example):

- Headquarters: Malmö (where many Arabic speakers live, but the council operates nationally)
- Board: 7 members elected by a census among Arabic speakers (simple election via SMS, one person one vote)
- First year's budget: SEK 9.6 million (20% of SEK 48 million)

- Task: Announce grants for poetry, short films, music production in Arabic. Build a website where applications are made in Arabic, assessed by Arabic speakers.

The Somali council:

- Headquarters: Rinkeby (Stockholm) or Borlänge
- Board: 5 members
- First year's budget: SEK 1.7 million

Evaluation after 2 years:

- Number of applications per language (target: at least 100 the first year)
- Proportion of funds going to previously marginalized cultural creators (without previous support from the Arts Council)
- Linguistic vitality—measured through a survey of speakers on whether they feel the language is used in cultural life more than before

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Swedish Arts Council's instruction (SFS 2015:162)**—add a new assignment: *"The Arts Council shall annually allocate 1% of its appropriations distributed to language community councils in accordance with the appendix. The language community councils decide independently on the distribution of grants within their language group."*
2. **New ordinance on language community councils**—defines how the councils are appointed (election among speakers, minimum transparency requirements, requirement for annual reports in Swedish and in the language).
3. **Exemption from the Discrimination Act**—since the grants only go to a specific language group, it could be perceived as discrimination against Swedish speakers. Add an exemption: *"Differential treatment on the basis of language is permitted when the purpose is to promote cultural diversity and preserve minority languages."*

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost
1% of the Arts Council's budget (SEK 12 billion × 0.01)	SEK 120 million
Of which to language communities (according to the table above)	SEK 114 million
Of which to administration (the Arts Council's processing of the councils)	SEK 6 million

Financing: Reallocation within the Arts Council. SEK 120 million is 1%—a minor reprioritization from large institutions. Alternatively, financing can be sourced from the Swedish Agency for Support to Faith Communities (which already has a similar model for religious groups).

Expected resistance and answers

"This is segregation—we are supposed to integrate, not be divided."

Answer: Integration is mutual. Today, minority language speakers are forced to adapt to Swedish to receive cultural support—that is assimilation, not integration. A true integration ideal allows different groups to express themselves in their own languages, and then meet in translation and exchange. Language community councils create visibility, not invisibility.

"Why should Swedish taxpayers finance Arabic poetry?"

Answer: Because Arabic speakers are Swedish taxpayers. They pay taxes just like everyone else. Today, they get almost none of their tax money back in the form of cultural support that reflects their language and traditions. It is an injustice. And besides: Arabic poetry produced in Sweden *is* Swedish culture—not foreign.

"The councils will be controlled by strongmen or religious forces."

Answer: That is why we require democratic elections within each language community (one person, one vote) and the publication of minutes and decisions. The risk is always there, but it also exists in the current system (e.g., that a small group of Stockholm curators controls the entire cultural budget). Transparency and the ability to dismiss council members are the remedy.

"Small language groups receive disproportionately little."

Answer: The per capita distribution is proportional. A group of 5,000 speakers receives 5,000/950,000 of the pot—approx. 0.5% = SEK 600,000/year. This is enough for a part-time position and a few small projects. It is fair. If you want to protect very small languages (e.g., Romani Chib, with a few thousand speakers), you can earmark an extra pot for "urgent language preservation."

"Won't the Arts Council sabotage this through bureaucracy?"

Answer: That is why we propose a separate ordinance that gives the councils independence. The Arts Council's role is limited to paying out money and verifying that the councils follow democratic rules—not assessing the quality of the applications.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **The Sweden-Finnish Association (Sverigefinska folkförbundet)**—already has a Finnish-language cultural committee, but without guaranteed funding.
- **The Swedish Agency for Support to Faith Communities**—distributes money to religious groups based on the number of members. The same model, but for languages.
- **The Sami Parliament's Culture Council**—distributes funds to Sami culture, including language preservation. Has been functioning since 1993. Why shouldn't Arabic speakers have the same right?
- **The Language Council of Norway**—provides support for Norwegian sign language literature. Finland has the "Society of Swedish Literature" for Swedish-speaking Finns. Sweden is lagging behind.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a Member of Parliament: Submit a motion to introduce language community councils with 1% of the cultural budget. Use the Sami Parliament as a model.

If you are active in a language community: Collect signatures from speakers in your municipality. Send them to the Committee on Cultural Affairs. Show that the demand exists.

If you are a culture secretary in a municipality: Start on a small scale—allocate SEK 50,000 for "translation support" for local poets in minority languages. Test the model locally.

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Cultural commons

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Summary: Transform 100 municipal cultural centers from professionally programmed institutions into community-controlled cooperatives (one member, one vote). 70% of the program is determined by local groups, 30% professionally curated. Resources (equipment, rooms, expertise) available to all members. The goal: break professional gatekeepers' monopoly over cultural expression and let cultural centers become toolboxes for residents' own creation—not stages for established actors.

The mechanism

Today, most municipal cultural centers are governed by officials and political committees. The program is determined by employed curators who book professional artists, exhibitors, and lecturers. Residents are passive consumers. The result: the same type of offering as in all other municipalities—standardized, safe, Stockholm-inspired.

The measure: Transform the cultural center into a **cultural commons**—a legal and organizational form where:

- The center is managed by a **cooperative** where everyone who uses the center can become a member (one member, one vote)
- **70% of the program budget** is determined by the members through member meetings or digital voting
- **30%** is reserved for professionally curated content (to retain quality-enhancing edge and invited guests)
- **Equipment** (camera, lighting, sound, workshop machines) is available for all members to borrow, often for free or at cost price
- **Rooms** can be booked by members for their own events free of charge (except for cleaning)

What it enables:

- A group of Somali women can book the main stage for a dance gathering without going through curators
- A teenager interested in rap can borrow professional recording equipment for a demo
- A pensioner's association can show their own film in the cinema

- Associations can collaborate on a theme night without paying expensive rent

Pilot design – ten cultural centers first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): Ten municipal cultural centers in different parts of the country are transformed into cultural commons. The selection is based on the municipality's willingness, the size of the center, and the composition of the population.

Pilot 1: Husby kulturhus (Stockholm)

- **Current status**: Professionally governed, with a high proportion of rented program activities. Residents often feel that the center does not reflect their needs.
- **Transformation**: Form a cooperative where everyone who lives in Järva (Husby, Akalla, Kista) can become a member (free or symbolic fee SEK 50/year). The first board is elected through a grassroots movement. The center's staff (curators, technicians) remain but get new roles—from "programmers" to "facilitators" who help members realize their own ideas.
- **Budget**: The municipality continues to pay for operations (heating, electricity, staff)—approx. SEK 5 million/year. The program budget (SEK 1 million/year) is distributed by the members.

Pilot 2: Blåsut kulturhus (Botkyrka)

- **Current status**: Mixed activities, but low resident influence.
- **Transformation**: Cooperative with a special place for language minorities. Each language group (Arabic, Kurdish, Spanish) can have its own "node" within the commons that receives a proportional share of the budget.
- **Budget**: SEK 3 million/year from the municipality + opportunity to sell memberships (SEK 50/month) for extra resources.

Pilot 3: Fågelviken community hall (Värmland countryside)

- **Current status**: Small cultural center mostly used by pensioners, with low activity among younger people.
- **Transformation**: Cooperative that also includes the community center, the school stage, and the library in a shared commons. Mobile resources (sound packages, stage lighting) that can be borrowed between towns.
- **Budget**: SEK 0.5 million/year from the municipality + EU rural development funds.

Evaluation after 3 years:

- Number of members in the cooperative (target: >20% of residents in the catchment area)
- Number of self-organized events per year (before: 5–10; after: >100)

- Proportion of the population who visited or used the center at least once a year (target: >50%)
- Perceived belonging and influence (survey)

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Local Government Act (2017:725)** – add a new section: *"Municipalities may transfer the management of cultural centers, libraries, or other public community premises to cooperative societies or foundations where the members are residents of the catchment area. The municipality remains the owner of the property and is responsible for basic operations."*

2. **Agreement template** – develop a standard model for a "cultural commons agreement" between the municipality and the cooperative, with clear rules for the division of responsibilities, budget frameworks, and the right of repossession if the cooperative mismanages itself.

3. **Exemption from rent regulation** – since members are allowed to use the rooms for free or at a low cost, this is exempted from the Act on the Leasing of Own Homes (privatuthyrningslagen). A small adjustment to avoid demarcation problems.

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost (per pilot)
Operations (heating, electricity, cleaning, security)	SEK 1–5 million (depending on size) – paid by the municipality as today
Staff (2–5 facilitators)	SEK 1.5–4 million – the municipality or the cooperative?
Program budget (member-governed)	SEK 0.5–2 million – the municipality
Training of facilitators (first year)	SEK 100,000 per center (one-time cost)
Digital platform for member democracy	SEK 50,000 per center (one-time cost)

Financing: Mainly municipal funds that already go to cultural centers. The difference is reallocation—from professional program purchases to member-governed activities. Net costs may decrease since members contribute with voluntary work.

Expected resistance and answers

"The curators will lose their jobs or be demoted."

Answer: No, their role changes. Instead of booking artists from Stockholm, they become facilitators who help members realize their ideas. This is more qualified work—tutoring a Somali group on using sound equipment requires pedagogy and technical knowledge, not less competence. Salaries may even increase as tasks broaden.

"The members will only book bad amateur culture."

Answer: Bad in whose eyes? A group of teenagers performing their own rap songs finds it meaningful. A pensioner's association showing slides from the 1960s has high nostalgic value. The taste of professional curators is not universal. Furthermore: 30% of the budget is still professionally curated—so there is always a "quality guarantee" for those who demand it.

"Politicians don't want to give up control."

Answer: They don't give up control—they delegate. The municipal council decides on frameworks (how much money, what security requirements, that operations follow laws). The cooperative decides on the content. The same model as for independent schools or housing cooperatives—proven.

"It will be unequal – certain groups will take over."

Answer: The risk exists, which is why clear democratic rules are required: all votes are equal, no permanent board positions, opportunity for re-election every year. The facilitators' role is to ensure that quiet voices are also heard—through special calls, targeted funds, and language support. If one group dominates completely, the municipality can retake management after a warning.

"Associations will outcompete individuals."

Answer: The commons is open to both associations and individuals. A single person can book a small room to paint—an association can book the main stage. Priority rules can be designed so that individuals get precedence at certain times. Democracy decides.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Kulturhuset Blåsut (Botkyrka)** – already experimenting with citizen dialogue today, but without a formal cooperative. Our model formalizes this.

- **Fryshuset (Stockholm)** – run as a foundation, not a cooperative, but has a similar idea of "young people govern themselves." Could be reorganized.
- **Bygdegårdarna (Community centers)** – traditional Swedish commons, often governed by non-profit associations. They are role models: self-government, low thresholds, local anchoring. Why can't municipal cultural centers function the same way?
- **Library makerspaces** – equipment is already available for members to borrow today (3D printers, sewing machines). Expand the concept to the entire cultural center.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Propose transforming one of your cultural centers into a "cultural commons" in pilot form. Use the community center model as an argument.

If you are an official in the cultural administration: Start on a small scale—give a local association the keys to a room once a week free of charge. Evaluate. Scale up.

If you are a citizen: Gather 10 people in your area and send a letter to the municipal executive board: "We want to take over the management of our local cultural center as a cooperative." Offer to be guinea pigs.

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A multicultural curriculum

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Summary: Replace the narrow canon (Vikings, the Middle Ages, 19th-century literature) with portfolio-based cultural heritage education. Students in Tensta document their families' oral traditions *at the same time* as they learn about Swedish history. The goal: that every student sees their own and others' cultural heritage as a resource, not a problem. Today, 20% of students with a foreign background are marginalized—their families' cultures are made invisible in the curriculum.

The mechanism

Today, the curriculum (Lgr22, Gy11) prescribes a "Swedish cultural heritage" that emphasizes:

- Viking Age and Middle Ages (Vikings, runes, medieval ballads)
- 19th-century literature (Strindberg, Almqvist, Lagerlöf, Topelius)
- Christian tradition (the church year, hymns, Bible stories)
- Swedish folk traditions (Midsummer, Lucia, miscellanea)

Content from other cultures is at best mentioned as "international perspectives" or "multicultural elements," but is not integrated into the core. Students with roots in Somalia, Iraq, Syria, Turkey, Chile, or Thailand get to learn a lot about Vikings but nothing about their parents' poetry, music, or history.

The measure: Introduce **portfolio-based cultural heritage education** where:

- Each student builds a portfolio of their own cultural heritage during their time in school
- The portfolio contains oral stories, recipes, songs, holidays, and crafts from the student's family or local environment
- The teaching includes comparative perspectives: "Viking burial customs and Kurdish burial traditions—what is similar, what is different?"
- National tests in history, Swedish, and civics always contain at least one assignment where the student must relate to a non-Swedish cultural heritage
- School libraries and teaching materials reflect this diversity (at least 30% of the titles in other languages or about other cultures)

What it enables:

- A Swedish-Somali student can write an essay about Somali oral poetry and compare it with Old Norse skalds
- A group of students with a Kurdish background can do a project on Newroz celebrations and connect it to Swedish spring traditions
- All students learn that cultural heritage is not a fixed list but living, changeable, and diverse

Pilot design – ten schools first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): Ten compulsory and upper secondary schools in different municipalities test portfolio-based cultural heritage education. The schools receive extra resources for teacher training, purchasing teaching materials, and collaborating with local cultural associations.

Pilot 1: Rinkeby School (Stockholm, grades F–9)

- **Student composition**: 95% foreign-born or with both parents born outside Sweden. Largest language groups: Somali, Arabic, Turkish.
- **Measure**: Introduce a subject called "Cultural heritage in practice" (2 hours/week) where students interview their parents and grandparents, record stories, and cook traditional dishes. Each semester, a portfolio (text, image, audio) is presented. The school collaborates with local associations (the Somali Cultural Association, the Turkish National Association).
- **Budget**: SEK 500,000/year (teacher resources, technology, association compensations).

Pilot 2: Vasa School (Kiruna, grades F–6)

- **Student composition**: A mix of Swedish, Sami, and newly arrived (from Syria, Afghanistan).
- **Measure**: Sami culture is integrated into all subjects (not just crafts and science). Students learn about Sami stories, reindeer husbandry, and duodji (crafts) alongside Swedish folk traditions. Newly arrived students contribute their stories about mountains and deserts—comparing living conditions.
- **Budget**: SEK 300,000/year (Sami teaching materials, study visits, lecturers).

Pilot 3: Lindeborg School (Malmö, grades 7–9)

- **Student composition**: High proportion of students with a background in the former Yugoslavia, Iraq, Afghanistan.
- **Measure**: Introduce a "history workshop" where students work with source criticism and oral history. Each student chooses an object, a story, or a tradition from their family and researches its origins, changes over time, and connection to Swedish history. Exhibition at the city library every semester.
- **Budget**: SEK 400,000/year (research technology, exhibition, publication).

Evaluation after 3 years (compared to control schools):

- Proportion of students who feel that the school "takes my background seriously" (survey)
- Difference in test results in history/Swedish (expected to increase as students become more motivated)
- Number of times teachers report conflicts between students from different backgrounds (expected to decrease)
- Parents' participation in school activities (expected to increase)

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the curriculum (Lgr22, Gy11)** – add to the syllabus for history, Swedish, and civics: *"The student shall be given the opportunity to explore and present cultural heritage from different parts of the world, with a particular focus on the traditions represented in their own class and local environment."* And: *"National tests shall contain assignments that require comparison between at least two different cultural traditions."*
2. **The Education Act's chapter on teaching materials (2010:800)** – add: *"One-third of school libraries and teaching materials shall consist of material in languages other than Swedish or that depicts non-Swedish cultural heritage."* Exemption for schools with an extremely homogeneous student composition (but they barely exist in today's Sweden).
3. **The Higher Education Ordinance regarding teacher education** – introduce a mandatory course in "multicultural didactics" (7.5 credits) for all prospective teachers in history, Swedish, and civics.

Budget and financing

Item	Annual cost
Pilot 10 schools (average SEK 400,000/each)	SEK 4 million
Continuing education for teachers (national, 10,000 teachers at SEK 5,000)	SEK 50 million (one-time cost first 2 years)
Development of new teaching materials (digital open resources)	SEK 5 million
Evaluation (research, three years)	SEK 3 million
Total first year	**SEK 62 million**
Annual operation after scaling up	**SEK 30 million** (teaching material updates, teacher guides)

Financing: Reallocation within the Swedish National Agency for Education's appropriation (total approx. SEK 80 billion/year). SEK 62 million is 0.08%—a negligible proportion. Can also be taken from funds for

"equal schooling" and "integration".

Expected resistance and answers

"Swedish children must learn Swedish history first."

Answer: Yes, and they do. The Viking Age, the Swedish Empire, 19th-century literature—all of this remains. But it is complemented with other perspectives. A student who learns about Sami culture or Kurdish poetry does not become worse at Swedish history—they learn to see connections and comparisons, which is a higher cognitive level. And it is not either-or; it is both-and.

"This is identity politics in school."

Answer: The current curriculum is also identity politics—it conveys a specific, narrow image of Swedishness. The question is what kind of identity politics we want: one that excludes 20% of the students or one that includes everyone? Highlighting the students' own backgrounds is not "political"—it is pedagogically sound. Research shows that students perform better when teaching connects to their experiences.

"The teachers don't have the energy—they already have too much."

Answer: That is why there are pilots first and a gradual implementation. Portfolio-based teaching is not extra work if it replaces something else (e.g., a traditional assignment on Strindberg). And the teachers receive continuing education and ready-made models. Many teachers already work like this informally—we formalize and support it.

"Parents with a Swedish background will protest—'my children shouldn't learn about Islam'."

Answer: Cultural heritage is not the same as religion. Learning about Kurdish Newroz or Somali poetry is about culture, not dogma. And if a parent protests against their child learning about *someone else's* cultural heritage—then we have an integration problem that rather confirms the need for the reform.

"The national tests will be impossible to grade fairly."

Answer: On the contrary—they will become fairer. Today, students who can refer to Strindberg and the Viking Age are rewarded. Students from other backgrounds have to struggle to reach the same frame of reference. With assignments that require comparison, all students can use their own knowledge and be assessed on equal terms. Grading guidelines are adapted—there are already models for this in international tests (e.g., PISA's assessment of multicultural texts).

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Mångkulturellt centrum (Botkyrka)** – has developed material for intercultural teaching, but it is used sporadically. Could be scaled up.
- **Sami teaching materials** – The Swedish National Agency for Education has already developed material on Sami history and culture. The same model can be used for other minorities.
- **"Berättarministeriet" (The Storytelling Ministry)** – works with writing and oral storytelling in vulnerable areas. Their methodology (portfolio, interviews, publication) is a role model.
- **Norway's "Cultural heritage in school"** – since 2020, the Norwegian curriculum has an explicit requirement that students must explore *their own and others'* cultural heritage. Sweden is lagging behind. Copy Norway.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a teacher: Test a small version—ask your students to interview a parent about a tradition and present it orally. Compare it with a Swedish tradition. See what happens with their engagement.

If you are a principal: Allocate SEK 50,000 to purchase teaching materials in other languages (e.g., books in Arabic, Kurdish, Somali) and start a "cultural heritage week" where students exhibit their portfolios.

If you are a local school politician: Submit a proposal to introduce portfolio-based cultural heritage education in a pilot project with 3–5 schools. Use the text above as a basis.

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